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Dancing bricks

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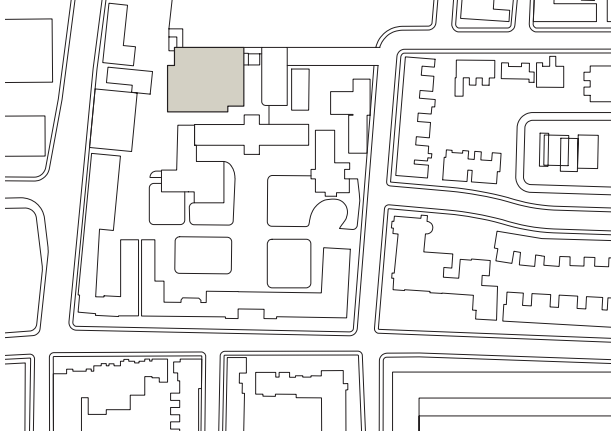
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Site plan

Dancing bricks

THE TAUT, ARCHING BRICKWORK OF THE RICHARD CAIRNS BUILDING SEEMS TO DEFY GRAVITY AS IT REACHES FOR THE SKY. THE SENSE OF MOVEMENT ECHOES THE SPIRIT OF THE BUILDING, A SPACE FOR TEACHING THE PERFORMING ARTS: DANCE, THEATRE AND MUSIC.

By Martin Søberg, PhD, architectural historian
Photos: Stijn Bolleart

Brighton College, a private boarding school, was founded in the mid-19th century. Gilbert Scott, one of the most prominent English architects of the day, used flint and sandstone in his design of both the main building and the attached neo-Gothic chapel and hall. Flint is commonly found on the nearby coast, embedded in the limestone layers on the cliffs or strewn across the beaches due to erosion of the cliffs. Over the past 15 years, Brighton College has greatly expanded, adding new buildings designed by various architects from the UK and abroad, to house a range of subjects and activities.

The latest addition is the Richard Cairns Building, which stands in the middle of the campus, between Gilbert Scott's main building and the large sports field known as Home Ground. It serves as a counterpart to the music building, and both are on the site's central axis. Designed by KRFT and Nicholas Hare Architects, the building connects two different ground levels, and spans four floors, including a basement.



Brighton College is only a few hundred metres from the sea. Brick is ideal for façades exposed to the salt, wind and rain of harsh coastal climates, which take their toll on buildings.

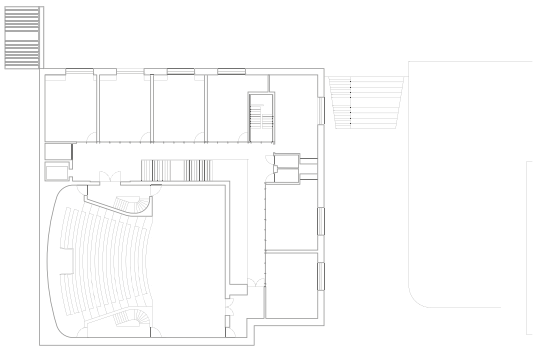


The cantilevered arch on the ground floor is made by rows of Kolumba courses, with each brick protruding slightly from the previous one. Photo: Annette Petersen

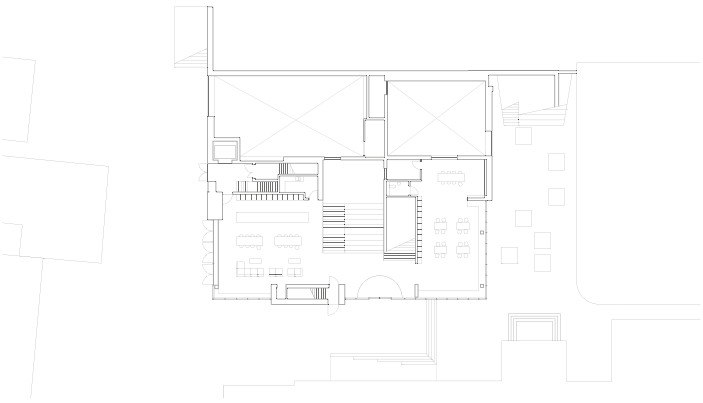
An intimate passage has been created between the main building and the Richard Cairns Building, with the entrance to the new building at roughly the half-way point on the façade.



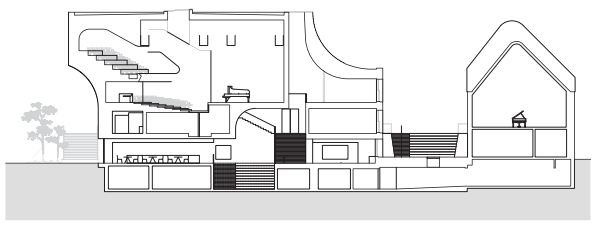
"We wanted a brick that doesn't feel new, but as if it has been there since time immemorial. A brick on which the patination process looks natural."
Thomas Dieben, architect



Plan, 2nd floor



Plan, ground floor



Section

The floors are linked by the staircase in the central atrium, where students meet and mingle. The ground floor houses a café and a lounge. The basement contains rehearsal rooms and two double-height studios for dance and theatre, with high windows that establish visual links both to the surroundings and to other spaces in the building, without seeming intrusive. The English and computer-science classrooms are clustered at an offset angle to the north-east on the first and second floors, while the upper south-west section houses a 400-seat theatre. The auditorium has a large round skylight, a recessed balcony and is clad in dark walnut, which completes the intimate atmosphere.

The theatre makes its mark on the exterior in the form of concave cantilevers to the west and south, which frame the main entrance. To the north, a half-arch rises straight out of the ground and forms an open veranda towards the sports field. Above the classrooms to the north-east, the cantilevers are countered by curved surfaces that swoop up towards the flat roof. The many curves, which vary in both proportion and direction, add a sense of movement, even dance, to the otherwise compact body. They also echo the neo-Gothic pointed arches and rose windows of the main building.

Both the outer walls and roof curves are clad in brick. The walls are in Kolumba in varying lengths, while the roof curves are clad in Cover.

"The façades and roof had to be made of a single material, so Petersen Tegl was ideal as Cover is made from exactly the same clay as Kolumba. While the curved parts were prefabricated, the bricklaying for all the vertical surfaces was done on site," explains Thomas Dieben, architect and founding partner of KRFT

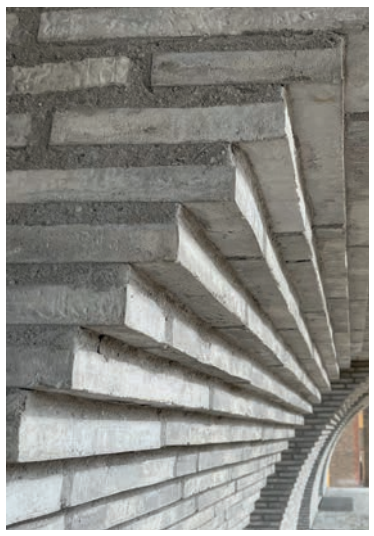
In homage to Gilbert Scott's main building, flint has also been incorporated into the masonry. It dominates the bottom of the ground floor, and is then used increasingly sparingly further up the façade, with brick eventually taking over completely.

"We wanted a light-coloured material that matched the neo-Gothic combination of flint and sandstone. We didn't want to use sandstone itself, but something more contemporary, which could be used in a different way. We also wanted



The cantilevers to the west and south support the balcony in the theatre, which means the exterior reflects the interior, and the curvature suggests a sense of motion. Visually, the bricks' format and colour variations create an effect reminiscent of textiles, with the curve resembling folded fabric rather than heavy brickwork.

The long, slender format of Kolumba makes it possible to produce a precise and refined relief effect that feels light and flowing despite the solidity of the construction. Photo: Annette Petersen





The classrooms have large windows facing the sports ground. They face north to avoid overheating.

"The façades and roof had to be made of a single material, so Petersen Tegl was ideal, as Cover is made from exactly the same clay as Kolumba."
Thomas Dieben, architect

The Richard Cairns Building, Brighton College, Brighton, UK

Client: Brighton College

Architect: KRFT in collaboration with Nicholas Hare Architects

Main contractor: Gilbert Ash

Civil engineer: Momentum

Landscape architect: Bradley-Hole Schoenaich

Completed: 2024

Brick: F563, C563, both in custom colours and based on K91 and C91

"Flint has a range of colours, from white to dark brown and black. We've brought all of these into the brick, which was made specially for the building."
Thomas Dieben, architect



The neo-Gothic main building, designed by Gilbert Scott, is made of sandstone and flint. The design of its windows and doorways inspired the curved shapes of the Richard Cairns Building.



Flint is interspersed with brick, but gradually less so higher up. The light and dark hues of the flint interact with the delicate shades of the Kolumba bricks. Photo: Edmund Sumner

a material capable of withstanding the coastal climate's salt, strong winds and heavy rain. Hence the marriage of flint and brick," says Dieben about the choice of brick.

While the darker, glossier flint contrasts with the lighter, more matte brick, the materials are also linked.

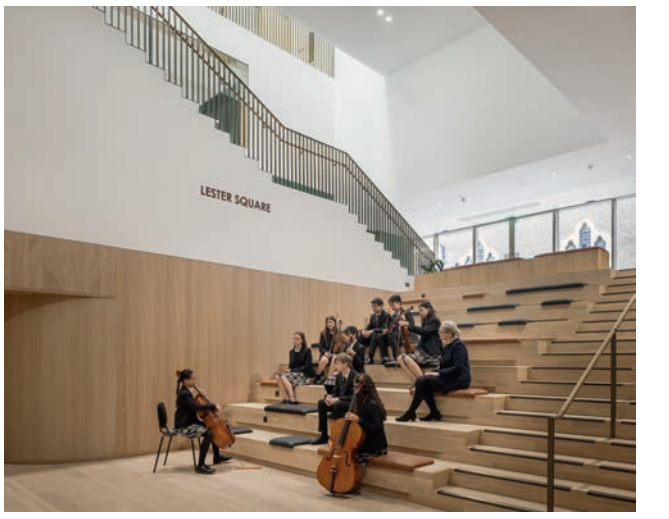
"Flint has a range of colours, from white to dark brown and black. We've brought all of these into the brick, which was made specially for the building. Based on K91 and C91, we refined a Kolumba and a Cover to incorporate a range of light and dark hues, and even some splashes of white. We wanted a brick that doesn't feel new, but as if it has been there since time immemorial. A brick on which the patination process looks natural," Dieben concludes.

The result endows the building with an almost geological feel, like a block cut directly out of the light-coloured English cliffs – but with a completely contemporary aesthetic.



The large ground floor window provides light to the double-height dance studio in the basement, creating a visual link to the street level without feeling intrusive.

The atrium in the centre of the building features wide steps, where students hang out and take a seat.





The taut, curved shapes of the theatre are clad in dark walnut.